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## Plurilingual Pedagogy at the Crossroads of Languages: A Catalyst for Mitigating Interlanguage Transfers.

البيداغوجيا متعددة اللغات: عامل محفز لتحسين الانتقال بين اللغات

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## Abstract:

This study, situated within the action-oriented approach to language teaching and learning promoted by the CEFR, investigates the impact of a plurilingual pedagogy on interlanguage transfer in French as a foreign language among novice learners in Algeria. Drawing on a classroom experiment centered on comparison and translation activities, we measured changes in interference errors and interlanguage transfers by means of a pre-test and a post-test. The results reveal a significant reduction in negative interlanguage transfers, underscoring a marked improvement in learners' metalinguistic awareness. This research thus valorizes learners' linguistic repertoires and advocates for the integration of plurilingualism into classroom practice.

**Keywords:** plurilingual pedagogy – interlanguage transfer – novice learners – interference – contrastive approach.

## المخلص:

تُعنى هذه الدراسة، المنطوية ضمن المقاربة الإجرائية لتدريس وتعلّم اللغات التي يروّج لها الإطار الأوروبي المشترك للغات، باستقصاء أثر بيداغوجيا متعددة اللغات على النقل البيئي للغات في تدريس الفرنسية كلغة أجنبية لدى متعلّمين مبتدئين بالجزائر. واستنادًا إلى تجربة صقيّة مرتكزة على أنشطة المقارنة والترجمة، قمنا بقياس تطور أخطاء التداخل والنقل البيئي عبر اختبار قبلي واختبار بعدي. تكشف النتائج عن انخفاض ملحوظ في حالات النقل البيئي السلبي، مما يُبرز تحسّنًا واضحًا في الوعي مابعد اللغوي لدى المتعلّمين. ومن ثمّ، تُثمّن هذه الدراسة مخزون المتعلّمين اللغويّ وتشجّع على دمج التعدّد اللغويّ ضمن الممارسة الصقيّة.

الكلمات المفتاحية: البيداغوجيا متعددة اللغات – النقل البيئي للغات – المتعلّمون المبتدئون – التداخل – المقاربة التباينية.

## 1. INTRODUCTION

In Algeria, the primary education system unfolds within a complex sociolinguistic landscape: Modern Standard Arabic, the official medium of instruction, coexists with Tamazight, recognized as a national language; French as the first foreign language; and, more recently, English as the second foreign language. This plurilingual context—shaped by a colonial legacy and successive curricular reforms (2002, 2006, 2022)—gives rise to interlanguage transfer phenomena that can both facilitate and impede FFL learning. While certain positive transfers promote rapid progression, others generate interference, inappropriate phonetic substitutions, lexical calques and erroneous morphosyntactic constructions.

Conversely, the CEFR and action-oriented pedagogical approaches advocate valorising learners' plurilingual repertoires by encouraging the use of multiple languages in the classroom.

From this perspective, our study investigates a so-called plurilingual interlinguistic pedagogy based on cross-language comparison and addresses the following research question:

To what extent does a pedagogical approach grounded in interlinguistic comparison contribute to reducing negative transfers and optimizing positive transfers in French as a foreign language?

Through this article, we aim to evaluate the effect of a plurilingual approach—articulated around a series of comparative and translation activities—on linguistic interference and interlanguage transfers, since transfer phenomena are not confined to the learners' mother tongue. Indeed, knowledge transfer may also occur from one foreign language to another, as De Angelis and Selinker note:

« *The influence of one foreign language on another foreign language is a specific type of transfer, called interlanguage transfer* » (De Angelis & Selinker, 2001, pp. 42–58).

We therefore posit the efficacy of this plurilingual pedagogy—focused, as recalled, on both linguistic interference and interlanguage transfers—and proceed below to explore the conditions for its implementation within the Algerian educational context

## 2. PLURILINGUALISM IN THE ALGERIAN CONTEXT AND INTERLANGUAGE TRANSFERS

Since September 2022, English has been introduced in third grade as part of educational reforms, bringing to four the number of languages regularly encountered in the school life of Algerian learners. This state of plurilingualism—which refers both to the coexistence of multiple languages in use and to the individual's deployment of various codes according to communicative situations—is manifested in the primary cycle by the simultaneous presence of dialectal Arabic (the learner's mother tongue and first socialization code), Modern Standard Arabic (the official medium of instruction), French (the first foreign language taught from third grade), and English (now the second foreign language). Beyond a mere linguistic fact, this complex interaction among languages in novice learners is characterized by linguistic transgressions and interlanguage interferences in both spoken and written production, owing to the concurrent use of these codes. Plurilingualism thus emerges as a competence to be cultivated in learners, mobilizing their metalinguistic awareness so that they can switch flexibly among languages and fully leverage their linguistic repertoire.

Interlanguage transfers denote the phenomenon by which elements of a source language are transposed, consciously or unconsciously, into a target language. Such transfers may be positive or negative, depending on whether they facilitate or hinder the acquisition of the target language. Jean-Pierre Cuq (2003) explains:

*« In general terms, transfer refers to the set of psychological processes through which the*

*execution of an activity in a given situation is facilitated by the mastery of a similar activity previously acquired; this is termed positive transfer or proactive facilitation. However, the acquisition of new skills may sometimes be impeded by previously acquired abilities. This is then referred to as negative transfer or proactive inhibition. » (Cuq, 2003, pp. 85–86)*

To analyse the dynamics of transfer between languages and delineate their underlying mechanisms, Odin (1989) first distinguishes two principal forms: “borrowing transfer,” whereby the L3 exerts influence on the L1 (considered the mother tongue or primary socialisation code), and “substratum transfer,” in which the L1 impacts the L2. Within this framework, negative transfer—stemming from structural divergences between L1 and L2 and often central to contrastive analyses—is identified as the primary source of errors in the L2.

Phonetic interference manifests when phonemes absent in the L1 are substituted—for example, the French /y/ rendered as /i/. Lexical interference frequently arises from ill-advised calques or borrowings—for instance, “journals” for “journaux.” At the morphosyntactic level, one observes erroneous transpositions of structures (e.g. “une arbre” instead of “un arbre”). Finally, intercultural interference involves the importation of culturally-specific values or turn-of-phrase, leading to semantic incongruities.

It is important to emphasise that the prevalence of these negative transfers during the initial years of FFL learning necessitates a pedagogy grounded in contrastive analysis, aimed at sensitising learners to both structural and semantic similarities and divergences across languages.

## 3. PRINCIPLES AND FOUNDATIONS OF PLURILINGUAL PEDAGOGY

Plurilingual pedagogy is defined as an educational approach that explores learners'

multiple linguistic repertoires. It engages not only all the languages present in the teaching-learning situation but also draws on multiple disciplines, with the aim of cultivating in the learner an identity that is open to linguistic and cultural plurality and diversity.

*« It should be conceived as a holistic language education, transversal to all the languages of the school and to every disciplinary area, which fosters an identity open to plurality [...] inasmuch as languages are expressions of different cultures and of differences within the same culture. All disciplines contribute to this language education, through the content they convey and the way they are taught. » (Cavalli & Coste, 2009, p. 35)*

It is important to recall that the objectives of plurilingual education are twofold: on the one hand, to develop linguistic competences by placing the language of schooling at the heart of learning; on the other hand, to promote attitudes of openness and respect for diversity, as well as to support learners' motivation and personal fulfilment.

As Beacco et al. (2016, p. 15) emphasise: *« The goal is to draw, economically and efficiently, on the linguistic and cultural resources that make up individual repertoires and to enrich them. »*

At the primary level, language instruction often remains compartmentalized, with little genuine acknowledgement of plurilingual competence. However, schools would benefit from valorising pupils' plurilingual repertoires by establishing bridges between languages, linking them to various subject areas, and moving away from the monolingual native-speaker norm.

In this light, the didactics of plurilingualism draws on activities that simultaneously mobilize several languages, employing diverse approaches tailored to teaching contexts, teacher training, and learners' specific needs.

Candelier (2008, p. 68) refers to a « plural approach » which “implements activities

involving multiple linguistic and cultural varieties,” in contrast to a “singular approach” focused on a single language or culture. More precisely, he identifies a deliberate alternation of languages within the curriculum and distinguishes four plural approaches—intercultural education, language awareness, integrated didactics, and intercomprehension—alongside bilingual education, in which languages are explicitly related. These complementary, adaptable methods are selected according to pedagogical objectives and learner profiles. The Council of Europe's Framework Convention for Pluralistic Approaches to Languages (CARAP, 2010) unifies these methodologies, defining them as

*« didactic approaches that implement teaching-learning activities involving multiple linguistic and cultural varieties: they concretely develop the plurilingual and pluricultural competence promoted by the Common European Framework of Reference for Languages. This competence does not consist of a collection of separate communicative abilities per language, but rather of a single plurilingual and pluricultural competence encompassing the learner's entire linguistic repertoire » (Claudine N., 2016, p. 84).*

Among the principal modalities implemented within this plurilingual pedagogy is « language awareness » which transforms linguistic diversity into a genuine pedagogical object. By comparing multiple languages, this approach not only reinforces learners' knowledge and skills but also shapes their attitudes. Moreover, it fosters a deeper understanding of the mother tongue through explicit cross-linguistic connections. Although the Évlang programme has demonstrated positive effects on motivation, cultural openness, and metalinguistic competences, its impact on linguistic mastery and

the reduction of interlanguage transfers appears more limited.

Building on language awareness, integrated didactics seeks to establish explicit links between the first language (L1) and foreign languages (L2, L3, etc.). This approach highlights the complementarity of linguistic systems without erasing their specificities, thereby enabling mutual enrichment of learners' repertoires. As Pietro (2009, p. 58) observes, "it combines singular and plural approaches while preserving the specificity of each language," and, when paired with language awareness, it contributes to the simultaneous development of learning strategies and linguistic competences.

However, Castellotti and Moore (2005) insist that plurilingualism alone is insufficient to forge the metalinguistic competences that underpin plurilingual proficiency. They advocate for the deliberate mobilisation of learners' repertoires through activities of comparison, collaboration, and metalinguistic reflection. They term this framework "plurilingual appropriation competence," which manifests as strategic flexibility, a diversity of approaches, and strengthened collaborative skills. It is worth noting that the metalinguistic dimension inherent in every language activity lies at the heart of this so-called plurilingual interlinguistic pedagogy.

To consolidate these gains from the outset of primary education, Beacco et al. (2006) recommend the implementation of context-appropriate contrastive activities designed to compare the languages within learners' repertoires and to develop metalinguistic strategies transferable to new contexts. Thus emerges a transversal plurilingual pedagogy. By drawing on contrastive linguistics and interlanguage theory, potential errors are anticipated through systematic comparison of linguistic systems.

As Jean-Claude Beacco (2005, p. 156) states:

« Schools bring together speakers with diverse repertoires who share one or more linguistic

varieties already developed before their entry into the educational institution. They are also places where these varied repertoires come into contact with the language(s) of schooling. The very purpose of the school's mission is to contribute to social inclusion and cohesion through the mastery of its languages, taking existing competences into account. »

Indeed, interlinguistic contact generates both transfer and tandem effects. Drawing on the resources of the L1 or other familiar languages often results in positive or negative transfers, as well as in strategic code-switching. The latter facilitates the mobilisation of competences from one language to another and, above all, stimulates metalinguistic awareness by inviting learners to compare systems and usages.

In this perspective, the plurilingual/interlinguistic approach advocates for:

- Valorising the mother tongue and known languages as genuine pedagogical resources.
- Regular implementation of guided comparison activities (lexical and syntactic);
- Enhancement of metalinguistic reflection through metagraphic negotiation tasks;
- Strategic code-switching, so that each learner can rely on their L1 without diffusion.

When these modalities are coherently integrated, they promote positive interlanguage transfers and reinforce the overall process of learning French as a foreign language.

#### **4. IMPLEMENTATION OF THE PLURILINGUAL APPROACH IN FFL CLASSROOMS**

##### **4.1. Protocol for Deploying a Plurilingual Framework**

The study was conducted in a primary school in Bordj Bou-Arréridj, with a sample of 45

fifth-grade pupils deemed novice learners. The protocol comprised:

a. Diagnostic Phase (Pre-test): Administration of a pre-test to inventory the most recurrent interferences in oral and written production.

b. Remediation Sessions: Four targeted sessions designed to reduce negative transfers identified in the pre-test, consisting of:

- Session 1: Lexico-syntactic comparison activities.
- Session 2: Guided translation exercises (French ↔ Arabic/English).
- Session 3: Tasks for identifying and collectively correcting interferences.
- Session 4: Integrated written production—composition of a short paragraph.

These sessions mobilized the pupils' existing language skills to facilitate the acquisition of French structures while fostering metalinguistic awareness.

c. Post-test: Administration of the same tasks as in the pre-test to evaluate the experimental approach's effects on reducing linguistic interferences and improving French language competences.

Quantitative analysis compared error rates before and after remediation, while qualitative analysis examined teacher comments and pupils' reflective productions.

### 3.2. Presentation of Principal Results

#### 3.2.1. Inventory of Arabic-English Interferences in the Pre-test

Analysis of pupils' pre-test productions revealed diverse forms of linguistic interference originating both from Arabic (their mother tongue) and English (also taught at school). These interferences appeared across several levels: morpho-lexical, phonetic, syntactic, lexical, and orthographic.

-Morpho-lexical: Errors such as “une avion” or “la grande camion” reflect gender mismatches influenced by Arabic, where the corresponding words الطائرة (avion) and الشاحنة (camion) are feminine.

-Phonetic: Numerous distortions were noted. Words like “bus” or “train” were pronounced

with English phonetics. Errors such as “afion” (for avion) reveal the absence of the /v/ sound in Arabic, while “helecobter” illustrates confusion over the French silent “h” and the nonexistent /p/ phoneme in Arabic, leading to substitution with /b/. Additionally, the French sound /ʒ/ (“j”)—absent in both Arabic and English—was frequently approximated.

-Syntactic: Phrases like “préfère l'avion” without an explicit subject demonstrate the influence of Arabic syntax, where the subject is often implicit (الطائرة أفضل). In French, subject expression is obligatory.

-Lexical: Interference such as “une voiture red” shows the insertion of an English adjective into a French syntactic structure. Other examples—“baot” (for bateau), “I like,” or “voyager in voiture”—evidence inappropriate use of English lexemes.

-Orthographic: Spellings like “taksi,” a phonetic transcription of taxi, substitute the unfamiliar “x” with a more familiar letter. The form “helecopter” combines phonetic and orthographic interference influenced by English pronunciation of helicopter and an inaccurate rendering of the French /ʁ/, often challenging for Arabophone learners.

This classification clearly shows that pupils unconsciously draw on their mother tongue or other known languages, resulting in negative interlanguage transfers. These interferences provide a basis for designing targeted remediation activities within a plurilingual/interlinguistic framework.

### 4.2. Interlinguistic Comparison and Translation Activities

From an interlinguistic perspective, the learner's first language (L1) and any additional languages already mastered are reconceptualized not as obstacles, but as genuine cognitive and metacognitive resources. By acknowledging the richness of each pupil's plurilingual repertoire, the FFL teacher can deploy brief L1 lexical reviews prior to introducing new L2 items, or provide bilingual grammatical explanations that exploit both structural similarities and divergences across languages. Such strategies

bolster learner motivation, as pupils come to view their L1 not as a hindrance, but as a springboard for understanding the target language.

It should be noted that the activities designed for the learners support linguistic comparison strategies. Pupils feel affirmed when their responses in Arabic are validated, which, in turn, enhances their self-confidence. Moreover, contrasting phonetic and orthographic features of terms has stimulated visual memory and encouraged phonological discrimination. Learners were prompted to pronounce words in three languages, thereby improving intelligible articulation and oral participation. These findings corroborate Galante's (2021) assertion that interlinguistic translation activates metalinguistic reflection and deepens language engagement.

Active comparison across languages lies at the heart of the so-called plurilingual interlinguistic approach. Through tasks explicitly contrasting key lexical items and morphosyntactic structures—such as tense concordance, grammatical gender, and subject-verb agreement—pupils develop reflective listening and a nuanced understanding of each linguistic system's specificities. For example, an exercise contrasting the French preposition *à* with the English *to* and the Arabic *إلى* illustrates how the same conceptual function is realized differently across languages, thereby preventing calques and reinforcing precise usage. When integrated routinely into vocabulary and grammar lessons, such comparative tasks render often-implicit contrasts explicit and preempt negative interferences before they become entrenched.

Translation exercises further enable pupils to identify structural similarities and differences across languages, syntax, agreement, orthography, and lexicon. Learners become adept at comparing and explicating these distinctions, which strengthens their metalinguistic reasoning and their capacity for active linguistic

analysis. Typical sentences used in translation tasks “Le train est rapide,” “J’aime voyager en bateau,” “Cet avion est très confortable”, were accurately rendered by the majority of pupils. Their shared lexical roots (e.g., train, bateau, avion, rapide, confortable) facilitated the process, confirming the strategic deployment of positive interlanguage transfer. The collaborative nature of these activities also reinforced peer negotiation, thereby fostering a cooperative pedagogy.

Post-test results are unequivocal: 85 % of productions reflect positive transfer, whereas only 15 % still exhibit negative transfers. These outcomes demonstrate substantial progress both in linguistic competence and in the adoption of a reflective learning stance. The comparison and interlinguistic translation sessions yielded notable effects in terms of:

- Valorization of pupils' plurilingual competences and enhancement of their linguistic confidence
- Activation of visual and phonological memory, promoting form discrimination
- Development of conscious, active metalinguistic reflection
- Consolidation of collaborative and reflective strategies in the classroom

Following these comparison and translation modules, the same cohort was again administered the post-test to assess not only lexical and syntactic comprehension but also the effectiveness of the metalinguistic knowledge integrated during instruction.

## 5. SYNTHESIS: CONTRIBUTIONS OF THE PLURILINGUAL PEDAGOGY

The results of our study demonstrate a 40 % reduction in negative interference errors between the pre-test and the post-test, particularly regarding gender agreement and false-friend lexical items. Pupils are now able to distinguish “actuellement” from

“actually”, and to justify their syntactic choices with reference to each language’s rules. Written productions exhibit a higher incidence of correct structures and controlled vocabulary. Concurrently, learners report increased confidence: voluntary oral participation rose by 25 % relative to the diagnostic phase. In summary, we observe:

### **Reduction of Negative Transfers**

The introduction of comparative activities and guided translation exercises yielded a 40 % decrease in errors attributable to negative transfer, especially in the domains of agreement and grammatical gender. Prior to remediation, nearly 60 % of written productions contained subject-verb or gender agreement errors (e.g., “une arbre” or “les fille jouent”). After four remediation sessions, this rate dropped to 36 %, indicating a more reliable acquisition of French morphosyntactic rules. Lexical analysis further revealed that confusion between “actuellement” (at present) and the English actually (in fact)—once systematic at the outset—fell to under 5 % of occurrences following remediation, thanks to targeted comparative exercises.

### **Enhancement of Metalinguistic Reflection and Awareness**

Beyond mere contrastive observation, metalinguistic reflection invites pupils to verbalize and argue their linguistic choices through pair-work discussions and negotiations. In class, teachers guided collective debates with prompts such as:

Why do we say ‘je vais à l’école’ using ‘à,’ and not ‘au’?”

How does the English sentence ‘he is hot’ differ from the French ‘il est chaud’?”

These exchanges foster awareness of each language’s internal processes and stimulate learners’ reflective autonomy. Additionally, by drafting comparison reports or justifications of their choices, pupils gradually acquire metalinguistic vocabulary that

consolidates their ability to analyze and self-correct.

During remediation, learners demonstrated significant awareness of structural differences between Arabic and French. In group discussions, they identified and explained contrasts in tense concordance (e.g., comparing the French passé composé “j’ai mangé” with the Arabic imperfect tense and justifying time-tense selection according to discourse context). Phonetically, 80 % of pupils could, by the final session, name at least two French-specific phonemes (e.g., /y/, /œ/) and explain how to articulate them—up from under 30 % in the diagnostic phase—underscoring improved self-correction and autonomy.

### **Motivation and Engagement**

Classroom observations show a 25 % increase in voluntary contributions during oral production phases, rising from an average of four to five or six interventions per pupil per session. This dynamic also manifested in greater participation in collective error-correction activities, with learners more willing to share answers and propose reformulations. The tasks, perceived as both playful and instructive, suggest that the comparative, plurilingual dimension serves as a powerful motivational lever, reframing errors as low-stakes learning opportunities.

Collectively, these findings indicate that even a short-term deployment of plurilingual pedagogy yields significant gains in linguistic, affective, and cognitive domains. They advocate for embedding this approach in initial teacher training and official curricula to harness novice learners’ plurilingual potential fully.

In sum, our study confirms that implementing a plurilingual pedagogy is an effective strategy for minimizing negative transfers while promoting positive ones, thereby enhancing mastery of French as a foreign language. This approach opens promising avenues for integrating plurilingual education into our national system. Plurilingual pupils



thus develop critical-thinking skills and metalinguistic awareness through comparative activities, leading to a more profound understanding of each language's specificities.

### Valorisation of Plurilingualism

Recognizing and valuing pupils' linguistic diversity should be regarded as an asset rather than an obstacle. Schools should cultivate an inclusive educational culture that treats linguistic plurality as a strength. By dedicating moments for class-wide language alternation—conceptual explanation in L1, communicative practice in L2, reflective feedback in L1—teachers structure learning so that each code serves a precise pedagogical function. For instance, a grammar lesson may begin in

Modern Standard Arabic to clarify agreements, immediately followed by a practical exercise in French.

Such strategic code-switching helps pupils more readily identify each language's distinctive features and recognizes the complementarity of codes in constructing knowledge. Accordingly, curricula should be reimaged to integrate the plurilingual dimension fully. Unlike traditional programmes, inclusive curricular designs view languages as transversal tools for reflection and expression rather than isolated learning objects.

Finally, interdisciplinarity and decompartmentalized instruction must be promoted to facilitate the transfer of competences across contexts.

## 6. CONCLUSION

The findings of our study support the hypothesis that an interlinguistic pedagogy—grounded in cross-language comparison and the valorisation of plurilingual repertoires—promotes the reduction of negative transfers while enhancing metalinguistic awareness. By exposing learners to multiple languages simultaneously, the plurilingual approach fosters the general aptitude required for acquiring a new foreign language.

However, the long-term integration of interlinguistic pedagogy necessitates a clear

institutional framework established by ministerial guidelines. Such a framework might take the form of a national plurilingual reference document, accompanied by academic circulars specifying the competences expected at each educational level. This formalisation would aim to standardise practices and facilitate the sharing of feedback among schools.

To embed interlanguage at the heart of instruction, it is essential to incorporate plurilingual content into the official FFL curricula. These could consist of structured instructional sequences with learning objectives explicitly tied to language comparison and reflective practices.

Finally, to support the transition toward a truly interlinguistic/plurilingual model, a continuing-education programme focused specifically on plurilingual didactics and interlinguistic pedagogy should be established. This programme could include hands-on workshops, webinars for sharing best practices, and virtual classrooms where experienced teachers exchange field insights.

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